

Milliken lauded as a beacon of Arlington civic life

by SCOTT McCaffrey, Staff Writer
Nov 15, 2017



John Milliken was saluted with the 2017 William T. Newman Jr. Spirit of Community Award by the Arlington Community Foundation.

John Milliken's Democratic Party bona-fides are secure – as secure as his stature as a civic leader who is simultaneously an elder statesman and an still-vigorous participant.

And yet, the former Arlington County Board member felt that the audience at the 2017 William T. Newman Jr. Spirit of Community Awards program should be let in on a little secret about one of his earliest experiences in the political arena.

In 1960, with his family just arrived in Arlington, the 14-year-old Milliken was living in the Buckingham neighborhood, attending Washington-Lee High School and was just getting active in politics.

The unusual twist?

“I was for Nixon rather than Kennedy,” Milliken acknowledged, joking that it was his most notorious youthful indiscretion.

The crowd at the Nov. 9 gathering – which, like Arlington in general, tended to veer Democratic in its leanings – forgave him, saluting Milliken with two standing ovations as he received the Arlington Community Foundation’s annual honor.

The luncheon ceremony was held at the Renaissance Arlington Capital View Hotel, where Milliken became the most recent award recipient and the latest in a line that stretches back to Joan Cooper in 1993.

“It’s hard to know quite what to say. I can’t begin to tell you how appreciative I am,” said Milliken, an attorney who served as Virginia’s secretary of transportation in the Wilder administration and currently chairs the Virginia Port Authority board of commissioners.

Milliken represents “the archetype of community spirit,” said U.S. Rep. Don Beyer (D-8th), among those on hand to congratulate the recipient.

Milliken has “an absolute gift for inspiring friendship and loyalty,” said Beyer. No matter the issue in the public arena, “You always want [him] on your team,” Beyer said.

(Both of Virginia's U.S. senators, who have known Milliken for decades, sent videotaped salutes. "In John, you picked a real winner," Sen. Tim Kaine said of Milliken's selection. "He's got a special passion for his home community. If it's going to be good for Arlington, you can count on John to help you out.")

Milliken has retired after a lengthy career with the Venable law firm. But there has been no lull in his day-planner: Milliken was asked by the County Board to chair a study of Arlington's facilities needs, and he currently heads the board of the Arlington Partnership for Affordable Housing.

Among those paying tribute was Mary Margaret Whipple, who served with Milliken on the County Board before each went to Richmond – he as secretary of transportation, she to the state Senate.

When Milliken was on the County Board, "I marveled at the way he would resolve issues," Whipple said. "He inspires the loyalty of others."

And, Whipple said, "his Rolodex is an item of envy" to politicians everywhere.

(Milliken and Whipple were joined on stage by Circuit Court Chief Judge William Newman Jr., who conceived the idea for the non-profit local community foundation and had served with the other two on the County Board. Newman joked that, had they still been on the five-member panel, "we would have had the quorum to pass anything we wanted to.")

Milliken's family left Arlington not terribly long after its arrival for a stint in Europe, then returned. Except for college and law school, John Milliken has been a resident ever since.

Why stay? "It was the people I met and got to know," Milliken said. "Those relationships were, and are, very special."

Arlington benefits from an inclusive governance structure that includes staggered terms for elected office-holders, giving voters "an outlet [for frustration] every single year," Milliken said. "It also means changes are incremental."

Jeanne Broyhill, who chairs the Arlington Community Foundation board, said the annual event not only paid tribute to Milliken (“one of Arlington’s most outstanding leaders”) but is a chance for those in the civic-engagement arena to enjoy each other’s company.

“Look around you and you’ll see a remarkable gathering of Arlington’s best and brightest and most committed,” she said.

Among those who have earned the Spirit of Community Award in past years: Elizabeth Campbell, Walter Tejada, Judy Connally, Rich Doud, Meg Tuccillo, Jonathan Kinney, Lola Reinsch and the duo of John Andelin and Ginger Geoffrey.

MORE INFORMATION



PHOTOS: Milliken lauded with 2017 Spirit of Community Award